

The Paradox of Gender Between Milton's Psyche and Religious Providence

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Paradise Lost is John Milton's magnum opus, an enthralling theodicy that has thrived since 1667. Within, Milton attempts to explain and glorify the ways of God to man by retelling the Christian canon. While he does so powerfully, it is not exempt from personal bias—his writing does indeed exemplify the omnipotence of God, but his human influence is seen throughout. The gendered language and ideologies of *Paradise Lost* are most significant for exalting God, but paradoxically superimpose Milton himself into the text, showing his personal biases, experiences, and pride—subverting the overarching message that Woman's Seed will produce the ultimate salvation and glory for God.

A paramount law within the universe of *Paradise Lost* is that of hierarchical dualism: all binary pairs have inherently superior and inferior halves, the most significant pair being male and female. The first mention of God shows that “on his right / The radiant image of his glory sat, / His only Son,” (Book III, 62-64) to immediately show the dominance of masculinity and light in Heaven. The Son of God is always referred to as the Son in some way, showing how his status as the male image of God is what makes him so supreme. However, from Satan is born femininity in the form of Sin, spawned on the “left side” (Book II, 755) of his head, unintentionally establishing hierarchical dualism into the universe to imitate God's perfection: his masculine to Satan's feminine, light to dark, right to left, Heaven to Hell. The constant bifurcation of these pairs helps to exalt God's righteousness from Satan's evil, creating clear moral standards through which Milton can depict right and wrong. Milton adheres to the Christian standard that man is superior to woman in this sense and uses this hierarchical dualism to explain how Adam is “for God only” while Eve is “for God in him,” (Book IV, 299) due to his valor, reason, and proximity to God as the masculine figure as opposed to Eve's feminine propensity to desire, beguilement, and narcissistic self-love, mirroring Satan's incestuous love of

his image in Sin. This starkness created by Milton's adept use of hierarchical dualism aids in his divine quest to support God's message.

A much more nuanced example occurs as he writes "That in his womb was hid metallic ore" (Book I, 673) to demonstrate the presence of precious metals in Hell. The entailing scene shows how the fallen angels greedily mine ores from Hell to create a profane imitation of Heaven's beauty within Hell. Hell's "womb" renders Hell as feminine, yet the word "his" implies male, creating a paradox. The truth comes in the form that Satan *is* Hell: "for within him Hell / He brings, and round about him, nor from Hell / One step no more then from himself can fly," (Book IV, 20-23) and since Satan and Hell are inherently feminine in comparison to the utter masculinity of God under their duality, it portrays Satan as a feminine "he" and satisfies the clash between the male pronoun and female womb. Furthermore, the image of the fallen angels violating Hell's, and therefore Satan's, womb, creates an explicitly homosexual and incestuous tension among those he calls his brethren or children, further exemplifying how his sin makes him feminine. This expands Milton's ideology even more and empowers it—while Satan is always referred to as a male, his inextricability to the Hellish, feminine side opposite of God's masculinity renders him as feminine no matter how masculine he may try to appear. This can be extrapolated to show that it is not just the outwardly gendered appearance of one that determines their fate, but the gendered actions they take: sin creates the feminine, reason and virtue create the masculine. Through this, Milton creates a retroactively radical and progressive view on gender in Christianity, widening its application to further achieve his goal of glorifying God.

While the dogma of hierarchical dualism strongly extols God, Milton's bias against women through his personal experiences also appear and muddle this message. For example, he

praises “wedded love, mysterious law, true source / Of human offspring,” (Book IV, 750-751) a heterosexual celebration of procreation, yet soon after writes:

Founded in Reason, Loyal, Just, and Pure,

Relations dear, and all the Charities

Of Father, Son, and Brother first were known. (Book IV, 755-758)

Undermining the beauty of the union of man and woman by instead focusing on male relationships hints at Milton’s frustration with women, likely founded by his history with his first wife Mary Powell. He further weakens the image of women through Eve’s origin story, as Eve recounts “Of sympathie and love, there I had fixt / Mine eyes till now, and pin’d with vain desire,” (Book IV, 465-466) when looking at her own reflection in a lake. This desire Eve feels for her own image is the key aspect of her character in her origin, and Milton makes it very clear that she must learn to love the virtue and spiritual beauty of Adam and subject herself to him, rather than fall to this narcissistic love. This exact flaw is seen in Satan, who fornicates with Sin:

Thy self in me thy perfect image viewing

Becam'st enamour'd, and such joy thou took'st

With me in secret, that my womb conceiv'd. (Book II, 764-766)

Satan creates his unholy trinity, the antithesis to God’s holy trinity, through his narcissistic and incestuous love for his own image in his daughter Sin. Furthermore, this is the first major sin he commits: while Satan commits hypocrisy and sin in his mind and heart before this, it the most blatantly outward sacrilege he first commits against God. Satan and Eve are linked through this weakness to their own image, Milton therefore weakening the sanctity of women in his epic. He

further reduces women by mirroring his relationship with Powell in Adam's with Eve, such as Eve's leaving from Adam resulting in the Fall being similar to Powell's abandonment of Milton, returning to him years later in shame just as Eve begs Adam for forgiveness. Another example comes in the subjection of Adam to Eve due to her overwhelming beauty—Adam only falls because he loves Eve more than he loves God and therefore puts her above God. After, he blames that mistake on her “too heav'nly form,” (Book X, 873) being seduced by his infatuation for her beauty that Raphael warned was worthy of “Thy cherishing, thy honouring, and thy love,” yet “Not thy subjection” (Book VIII, 569-570). This is uncannily similar to Milton's distress at his own fall, as he made a solemn vow with God in life to remain a chaste virgin as a sign of his respect for the heavenly inspiration to write *Paradise Lost*, which he believes he uniquely received from God, seen in the heavenly Muse he invokes throughout the epic. Milton remained steady on this promise until he met Mary Powell and became enamored, marrying her and having children with her. Ironically, Milton became blind years later, and he believed it a punishment from God for his mistakes, chief among them his severing of his holy vow, just as Adam completed Original Sin due to his superficial love for Eve's body. There is even an unnecessarily unfair disparity in the origins of Adam and Eve: Adam relates that as he first awoke to life, “Strait toward Heav'n my wondring Eyes I turnd,” (Book VIII, 257) showing his direct link with God, who is very often seen as a voice or cloud in the sky. In contrast, Eve awakens “Under a shade of flow'rs,” (Book IV, 451) cut off from the sky and God, and the first thing she perceives as the sky, “Pure as th' expanse of Heav'n,” (Book IV, 456) is actually her reflection in the water she looks down upon, showing how her key tie to her own image is what defines her rather than her connection to God. While it is important to demonstrate man's connection with God and his superiority over woman according to Christianity, Milton sometimes goes too far in cutting off

women from their spirituality or tying them too closely to Satan and his sin. One can argue that it was Eve who committed the majority of Original Sin, but as Michael explains, “From Mans effeminate slackness it begins . . . who should better hold his place / By wisdom, and superiour gifts receav'd” (Book XI, 634-635) over women, therefore showing how Adam bears responsibility for the Fall by letting Eve separate from him, despite knowing that the dangerous temptation of Satan would be too much for her.

Milton’s personal experiences with women seeping into the story is so crucially erroneous because it serves to undercut the most important culmination of the entire poem: the paradox of the fortunate fall through and redemption only through Woman’s Seed. This paradox entails the fact that the Fall, which unleashes unimaginable pain and suffering into an utterly perfect pre-Fall world, actually ends up creating exponentially more unimaginable joy, grace, and glory for God in the end. This is only due to the Son’s prophecy, which he speaks to Satan: “Her Seed shall bruise thy head, thou bruise his heel” (Book X, 181), meaning that the progeny of Eve will eventually lead to the incarnation of the Son in Jesus, who will triumph over Sin and Death to create “Paradise, far happier place Then / this of Eden, and far happier daies,” (Book XII, 464-465) eternal bliss on Heaven and Earth. The phrase “Her Seed” is mentioned many times throughout the poem after the Son first mentions it, accentuating to the utmost how the Son of God in man, who will achieve the perfect victory in the name of God, can only come from the Seed of Eve, a woman, only from her “sorrow” from “conception” (Book X, 193-194) and repentance for the sin she committed. Therefore, Milton’s use of gendered language and ideology pristinely extols God, yet his personal bias in the same vein serves to weaken women and the prophecy of Woman’s Seed, consequentially thwarting the omnipotence of God he wishes to laud above all.